architecture, little clues of what's outside, further up the hill, the difference blurring between nature and nurture. It becomes more indistinguishable, the power balance shifting as I reach further. It's like an arm wrestle, one slowly giving away to another. I am winning when everything is hurting but I am still gaining ground, carrying my burden uphill alone. There are no longer any paths marking my way. I am just on the road, occasionally blending into the shrubs to make way when a car goes past.

I know when I have reached it. I'm kicked with giddiness, as if I've happened upon the edge of the universe, for a moment unbalanced and teetering on something else. It's like I'm mainlining some other truth, some other possibility. I turn around, to see how far I have come. I am blissfully and completely alone. I check my watch. I've been walking for three hours uninterrupted. There is nothing but sheep and an old road sign. Heptonstall is another nine and a quarter miles. I don't have time to get there. I do, though, have time to sit here for a moment.

In front of the stone wall, on Robin House Lane, there is a gentle T-junction, the third option being a left to Colne, and a bench raised by wild growth. I clamber this final, small hilly increase towards the bench and, on sitting on it, notice it looks back on the entire stretch of Burnley. I take in the sight – an entire overview of where I live. It's my whole world, my past and my future. It could be this and holidays to Skipton to eat cheese toasties forever. From here, my school is just a dot amongst many dots, as inconsequential as the shooting stars that sometimes flicker across the northern sky. There's nothing keeping me in Burnley, apart from my family, I think to myself. I think of the careers advisor who has recently come in to talk to us and, when I said I'd like to play sport, they sarcastically spat back at me: 'Oh, you must be good then,' and laughed. Maybe she's right. After all, has anyone come from Burnley that I've seen playing sport on television? There was a gymnast once, I'm told, and Mark Harvey played for Lancashire and drove back into town with a Peugeot 206 with his name on it, but that's as many as I know.

It's peaceful here, on the outside of it all. *I wish I could be someone else*, I think to myself again. I want to be someone who isn't such an easy target, someone who isn't so small. I think it again and again until it becomes its own sort of mantra. I wish I could be somewhere else, a place where my shyness and awkwardness were inverted and sucked out of my